

P1857R2

Modules Dependency Discovery

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Abstract

The changes to `import` in [\[P1703r1\]](#) were both too much and not enough to enable fast dependency scanning via partial preprocessing. It made `import` at the start of a line anywhere in the program an *import-keyword*, breaking things like `import ->doImport ( ) ;`. Also, no similar changes were applied to `module`. This paper fine-tunes the context-sensitivity of `import` and `module`, applying the fixes discussed on the reflector. This resolves US026, US121, US125, GB126, US127, US128, US136, US137, US138, US139, US140.

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§ 1. Change Log

- R2
 - Add wording that rejects `#includes` from turning into imports in the purview of a module.
 - Reword how directive-introducing token is defined.
 - Make it ill-formed to have an object like macro with the names `export`, `module`, or `import` defined when they are used as a directive.
 - Restrict the global module fragment to preprocessing directives that start with `#`.
- R1
 - Added an example of using `#if` to change the module declaration.
 - Clarified benchmark.
 - Adding token backtracking feedback from implementors.

§ 2. Effects of This Paper

At the start of phase 4 an `import` or `module` token is treated as starting a directive and are converted to their respective keywords iff:

- After skipping horizontal whitespace are
 - at the start of a logical line, or
 - preceded by an `export` at the start of the logical line.
- Are followed by an identifier pp token (before macro expansion), or
 - `<`, `"`, or `:` (but not `::`) pp tokens for `import`, or
 - `;` for `module`

Otherwise the token is treated as an identifier.

Additionally:

- The entire `import` or `module` directive (including the closing `;`) must be on a single logical line and for `module` must not come from an `#include`.
- The expansion of macros must not result in an `import` or `module` directive introducer that was not there prior to macro expansion.

- A `module` directive may only appear as the first preprocessing tokens in a file (excluding the global module fragment.)
- Preprocessor conditionals shall not span a module declaration.

Failure to meet these additional requirements makes the program ill-formed (rather than not being interpreted as a directive).

Status Quo	This Paper
<pre>export module x ; // ✓</pre>	<pre>export module x ; // ✗</pre>
<pre>// -Dm="export module x;" m // ✓</pre>	<pre>// -Dm="export module x;" m // ✗</pre>
<pre>module; #define m x export module m; // ✓</pre>	<pre>module; #define m x export module m; // ✓</pre>
<pre>module; #if F00 export module foo; // ✓ #else export module bar; // ✓ #endif</pre>	<pre>module; #if F00 export module foo; // ✗ #else export module bar; // ✗ #endif</pre>
<pre>module; #define EMPTY EMPTY export module m; // ✓</pre>	<pre>module; #define EMPTY EMPTY export module m; // ✗</pre>
<pre>#if MODULES module; export module m; // ✗ #endif</pre>	<pre>#if MODULES module; export module m; // ✗ #endif</pre>

Status Quo	This Paper
<pre> #if MODULES export module m; // ✓ #endif </pre>	<pre> #if MODULES export module m; // ✗ #endif </pre>
<pre> module y = {}; // ✗ ::import x = {}; // ✓ ::module y = {}; // ✓ import::inner xi = {}; // ✗ module::inner yi = {}; // ✓ namespace N { module a; // ✓ import b; // ✗ } #define MAYBE_IMPORT(x) x MAYBE_IMPORT(import <a>; // ☠) #define EAT(x) EAT(import <a>; // ☠) void f(Import *import) { import->doImport(); // ✗ } </pre>	<pre> module y = {}; // ✖ ::import x = {}; // ✓ ::module y = {}; // ✓ import::inner xi = {}; // ✓ module::inner yi = {}; // ✓ namespace N { module a; // ✖ import b; // ✖ } #define MAYBE_IMPORT(x) x MAYBE_IMPORT(import <a>; // ☠) #define EAT(x) EAT(import <a>; // ☠) void f(Import *import) { import->doImport(); // ✓ } </pre>

Legend:

- ✓ The declaration was accepted, but may not be a modules declaration.
- ✖ A token was identified as a modules keyword, but the program is later found to be ill-formed.
- ✗ Ill-formed.
- ☠ Undefined behavior

§ 3. Motivation

§ 3.1. Fast Dependency Scanning

Fast dependency scanning relies on partial preprocessing. Several people are working on fast dependency scanning for modules, and they all share the common trait of skipping over non-directives. [clang-scan-deps](#) is one such tool and is a representative motivating usecase for these changes.

clang-scan-deps works by minimizing source code via partial preprocessing. Partial preprocessing works by running phases 1-3 of translation. Minimization proceeds by throwing away every line which is not a preprocessing directive, then removing all preprocessing directives that can't impact the set of dependencies for that file. Up to C++17 this means it only needs to keep `#define`, `#undef`, `#if*`, `#else`, `#elif`, `#endif`, and `#include`. And only the bodies of `#ifs` that contain a preprocessing directive that could impact dependencies. This reduces most files down to their header guards and list of `#includes`, and is correct for standard C++ except for abuse of `__LINE__` such as `#if __LINE__ > 456`. The only other things that break it are compiler extensions which do not follow the parsing rules of `#` directives such as `_Pragma("push_macro(\"X\")")`, or `.incbin` in inline assembly. Additionally, abuse of the compiler extension `__COUNTER__` can break this.

This minimization is context free, and is done *once* for each file in the entire build.

Then the minimized source file is fully preprocessed by running phases 1-4, with `#includes` resolving to their minimized equivalent, macros expanded, and all preprocessing directives executed.

Minimization followed by using clang's full preprocessor currently provides about a 9x speed up (~3 seconds vs ~28 seconds out of a 15m build on a 18 core iMac Pro) over no minimization at scanning all of llvm and clang (~7k files and ~3.8m LoC). We do not have access to a large C++20 modules only (no header units) codebase to do tests on, but that case still requires scanning the entire file due to the potential for `#include` based [x-macros](#) which will not be going away with modules, as they are intentionally non-modular includes. There will still be a difference in that we no longer have normal includes, and thus don't need to preprocess a header for each TU it's used in.

Of the 3s only 33ms are spent minimizing, while the majority of the time is spent in the full lexer, preprocessor, and header search. We believe we can reduce this overhead. This overhead is important as it's on the critical path. Any speedup here turns into a direct reduction in build latency, which is important for extremely parallel builds.

C++20 currently breaks this approach. [\[P1703r1\]](#) resolved the issue for `import`, but dependency scanning also needs to find `module` declarations, and the current rules are not enough.

§ 3.2. `import` is Too Relaxed

[P1703r1] went too far in fixing the dependency scanning issue with `import`. Now any line starting with `import` is treated as an import directive, even if it obviously couldn't be. This breaks a decent amount of real code with function arguments or local variables named `import`, as any use of them without a prefix is treated as an import directive, and prepending `::` doesn't work, you must wrap some part of the expression in `()`.

§ 4. Discussion

§ 4.1. Implementation

There were some concerns expressed during the discussion of [P1703r1] that there may be performance or complexity issues. I have implemented this fix in Clang. It was rather simple to implement, with the most complex part being doing token lookahead while lexing (which isn't that complicated). Measurement did not show any performance impact, which I expect to be due to the codepath only occurring with the `import` and `module` tokens.

§ 4.2. One Line Restriction

To be fully resilient, a module's directive must be entirely on a single logical line. You could have a rule that the `;` must not come from a macro and say that the directive extends to the next `;`, but that is incorrect:

```
#define f(x) "blah" #x "blah"
import f(
    ;
);
```

§ 4.3. Extra Dependencies

```
#define eat(x)
eat(
    import <a>;
);
```

In the WD this has undefined behavior due to [\[cpp\]/2](#)

A preprocessing directive consists of a sequence of preprocessing tokens that satisfies the following constraints: The first token in the sequence, referred to as a directive-introducing token, is a `#` preprocessing token, an import preprocessing token, or an export preprocessing token immediately followed by an import preprocessing token, that (at the start of translation phase 4) either begins with the first character in the source file (optionally after white space containing no new-line characters) or follows white space containing at least one new-line character.

and [\[cpp.replace\]/11](#)

If there are sequences of preprocessing tokens within the list of `[macro]` arguments that would otherwise act as preprocessing directives, the behavior is undefined.

A minimizer will transform this into just `import <a>;` which when preprocessed will form a valid module import. There are two outcomes of this:

- The dependency scanner emits an error because `<a>` is not a header unit or it is able to detect the usage in a macro.
- The dependency scanner succeeds and then the compiler sees the code and ~~ignores imports/errors~~ due to undefined behavior.

This is not the best outcome, as an implementation is not guaranteed to emit a diagnostic, from my tests of clang, msvc, gcc, and icc, only clang rejects `#include` in this case, and no compiler rejects an import directive (I plan to fix this in clang as part of implementing P1703 and this paper). This should be fixed by changing [\[cpp.replace\]/11](#) to be ill-formed instead of UB, but that deserves a separate paper. With that change though the possible outcomes would be:

- The dependency scanner emits an error because `<a>` is not a header unit or it is able to detect the usage in a macro.
- The dependency scanner succeeds and then the compiler sees the code and rejects it because directives cannot appear as a macro argument.

Both of these outcomes are fine as their result is the same. If a partial preprocessing would ever get the dependencies wrong, the compiler will reject the program as ill-formed.

§ 4.4. Ship Vehicle

This needs to ship with modules as this is a backwards incompatible change. Thus it needs to be in C++20.

§ 5. Wording

§ 5.1. [lex.pptoken]

```
preprocessing-token:  
    header-name  
    import-keyword  
    module-keyword  
    export-keyword  
    ...
```

4 The *import-keyword* is produced by processing an import directive ([cpp.import]), and the *module-keyword* is produced by preprocessing a module directive ([cpp.module]), and the *export-keyword* is produced by preprocessing either of the previous two directives. and has no [Note: None have any associated grammar productions observable spelling . —end note]

§ 5.2. [lex.key]

Add *import-keyword*, *module-keyword*, and *export-keyword* to Table 5: Keywords [tab:lex.key].

§ 5.3. [basic.link]

```
translation-unit:
    top-level-declaration-seqopt
    global-module-fragmentopt module-declaration top-level-declaration-...
private-module-fragment:
    modulemodule-keyword : private ; top-level-declaration-seqopt
```

...

3 A token sequence beginning with **export**_{opt} **module** and not immediately followed by **::** is never interpreted as the *declaration* of a *top-level-declaration*.

§ 5.4. [module.unit]

```
module-declaration:
    exportexport-keywordopt modulemodule-keyword module-name module-par...
```

§ 5.5. [module.import]

```
module-import-declaration:
    exportexport-keywordopt import-keyword module-name attribute-specif...
    exportexport-keywordopt import-keyword module-partition attribute-s...
    exportexport-keywordopt import-keyword header-name attribute-specif...
```

§ 5.6. [module.global]

```
global-module-fragment:
    modulemodule-keyword ; top-level-declaration-seqopt
```

§ 5.7. [cpp.pre]

1 A *preprocessing directive* consists of a sequence of preprocessing tokens that satisfies the following constraints: At the start of translation phase 4, the ~~The~~ first token in the sequence, referred to as a *directive-introducing token*, begins with the first character in the source file (optionally after white space containing no new-line characters) or follows white space containing at least one new-line character, and is

- a `#` preprocessing token, or
- an `import` preprocessing token, ~~or an `export` preprocessing token immediately followed by an `import` preprocessing token,~~ immediately followed on the same logical line by by a *header-name*, `<`, *identifier*, or `:` preprocessing token, or
- a `module` preprocessing token immediately followed on the same logical line by an *identifier*, `:`, or `;` preprocessing token, or
- an `export` preprocessing token immediately followed on the same logical line by one of the two preceding forms.

~~that (at the start of translation phase 4) either begins with the first character in the source file (optionally after white space containing no new-line characters) or follows white space containing at least one new-line character.~~ The last token in the sequence is the first token in the sequence that is immediately followed by whitespace containing a new-line character that follows the first token in the sequence. A new-line character ends the preprocessing directive even if it occurs within what would otherwise be an invocation of a function-like macro. [Example:

```
# // preprocessing directive
module ; // preprocessing directive
export module leftpad; // preprocessing directive
import <string>; // preprocessing directive
export import "squeue"; // preprocessing directive
import rightpad; // preprocessing directive
import :part; // preprocessing directive
```

```
module // not a preprocessing directive
; // not a preprocessing directive
```

```
export // not a preprocessing directive
import // not a preprocessing directive
foo; // not a preprocessing directive
```

```
export // not a preprocessing directive
import foo; // preprocessing directive (ill-formed at phase...
```

```
import :: // not a preprocessing directive
import -> // not a preprocessing directive
```

◀ —end example] ▶

preprocessing-file:

group_{opt}

module-file

...

module-file:

pp-global-module-fragment_{opt} pp-module group_{opt} pp-private-module-f...

pp-global-module-fragment:

module ; new-line group_{opt}

pp-private-module-fragment:

module : private ; new-line group_{opt}

control-line:

include *pp-tokens new-line*

~~**export_{opt} import pp-tokens new-line**~~

pp-import

...

2 A ~~text line shall not begin with a # preprocessing token~~ sequence of preprocessing tokens is only a text-line if it does not begin with a directive-introducing token. A *conditionally-supported-directive* shall not begin with any of the directive names appearing after a # in the syntax. A *conditionally-supported-directive* is conditionally-supported with implementation-defined semantics.

³At the start of phase 4 of translation the *group* of a *pp-global-module-fragment* shall neither contain a *control-line* not starting with a # preprocessing token nor a *text-line*.

§ 5.8. [cpp.module]

Add a new section before [cpp.import]: Module directive [cpp.module]

pp-module:

export_{opt} **module** *pp-tokens*_{opt}; *new-line*

1 A *pp-module* shall neither appear in a context where **module** is an identifier defined as an object-like macro nor where **export** is an identifier defined as an object-like macro if the first token of the *pp-module* is **export**.

2 Any preprocessing tokens after the **module** preprocessing token in the *module control-line* are processed just as in normal text. [Note: Each identifier currently defined as a macro name is replaced by its replacement list of preprocessing tokens. —end note]

3 The **module** and **export** (if it exists) preprocessing tokens are replaced by the *module-keyword* and *export-keyword* preprocessing tokens respectively. [Note: This makes the line no longer a directive so it is not removed at the end of phase 4. —end note]

§ 5.9. [cpp.import]

Insert a new paragraph immediately after the grammar.

A *pp-import* shall neither appear in a context where **import** is an identifier defined as an object-like macro nor where **export** is an identifier defined as an object-like macro if the first token of the *pp-import* is **export**.

Insert a new paragraph after paragraph 1

If an *import-directive* is produced by source file inclusion (including by the rewrite produced when a **#include** directive names an importable header) while processing the *group* of a *module-file*, the program is ill-formed.

Update paragraph 2

In all three forms of *pp-import*, the **import** and **export** (if it exists) ~~token~~ preprocessing tokens ~~is~~ are replaced by the *import-keyword* and *export-keyword* ~~token~~ preprocessing tokens respectively. [Note: This makes the line no longer a directive so it is not removed at the end of phase 4. —end note] Additionally, in the second form of *pp-import*, a *header-name* token is formed as if the *header-name-tokens* were the *pp-tokens* of a **#include** directive. The *header-name-tokens* are replaced by the *header-name* token. [Note: This ensures that imports are treated consistently by the preprocessor and later phases of translation. —end note]

§ 5.10. [cpp.glob.frag]

Remove this section.

```
pp-global-module-fragment:  
module ; pp-balanced-token-seq module  
pp-balanced-token-seq:  
pp-balanced-token  
pp-balanced-token-seq pp-balanced-token  
pp-balanced-token:  
pp-ldelim pp-balanced-token-seqopt pp-rdelim  
any preprocessing-token other than a pp-ldelim or pp-rdelim  
pp-ldelim: one of  
( [ { <: <%  
pp-rdelim: one of  
) ] } :> %>
```

1 If the first two preprocessing tokens at the start of phase 4 of translation are `module ;`, the result of preprocessing shall begin with a `pp-global-module-fragment` for which all preprocessing-tokens in the `pp-balanced-token-seq` were produced directly or indirectly by source file inclusion (`[cpp.include]`), and for which the second module preprocessing-token was not produced by source file inclusion or macro replacement (`[cpp.replace]`). Otherwise, the first two preprocessing-tokens at the end of phase 4 of translation shall not be `module ;`.

§ 5.11. [diff.cpp17.basic]

The editor should consider a different section of annex C to move this to.

Affected subclauses: [basic.link], [module.unit], and [module.import]

Change: New identifiers with special meaning.

Rationale: Required for new features.

Effect on original feature: ~~Top-level declarations~~ Logical lines beginning with `module` or `import` may be ~~either ill-formed or~~ interpreted differently in this International Standard. [*Example:*

```
class module {};  
module *m1;           // ill-formed; previously well-formed  
::module *m2;        // OK  
module m1;           // was variable declaration; now module-declaration  
module *m1;          // OK
```

```
class import {};  
import j1;           // was variable declaration; now import-declaration  
::import j2;         // variable declaration
```

— *end example*]

§ 6. Acknowledgments

Thanks to Boris Kolpackov for writing P1703, Mathias Stearn and Walter Brown for feedback on this paper and to Richard Smith, Corentin, Gabriel Dos Reis, Ben Craig, Matthew Woehlke, and Nathan Sidwell for discussion regarding this issue.

§ References

§ Informative References

[P1703r1]

Boris Kolpackov. [Recognizing Header Unit Imports Requires Full Preprocessing](https://wg21.link/p1703r1). 19 July 2019.

URL: <https://wg21.link/p1703r1>